

What Jesus Says to the Seven Churches

Seven Churches, Seven Conditions, and Seven Possible Ages

The letters to the seven churches in Revelation 2–3 are among the most searching words Jesus Christ ever spoke to His Church. They are not primarily letters from John. They are messages from the risen and glorified Christ Himself. John records what he was commanded to write, but the Speaker is Jesus.

Again and again, Christ says, “*I know your works.*” He sees what is happening inside His churches. He knows their faithfulness, suffering, compromises, doctrinal failures, spiritual weakness, and even the condition of their hearts.

These seven churches were real congregations located in Asia Minor, in what is now modern Turkey. They were not imaginary churches, nor were they merely symbols. They existed in the first century and received specific messages addressing their actual spiritual conditions. At the same time, the selection of seven churches is significant because seven frequently carries the idea of completeness in Scripture. Many interpreters therefore understand these churches as representative of recurring conditions found throughout the Church.

There is also a third interpretation that has attracted considerable attention throughout Church history: the possibility that the seven churches portray, in sequence, a broad progression through the history of the Church. This is often called the *prophetic, historical, or church-age* interpretation. It should be distinguished from the first-century historical meaning and from the representative meaning.

The safest approach is not to choose only one of these interpretations. The letters can be understood as having a threefold significance:

1. They addressed seven actual churches in the first century.
2. They describe spiritual conditions that can exist in churches in every generation.
3. They may also provide a broad prophetic pattern through the history of the Church.

The third interpretation is possible and remarkably interesting, but it should be held as an interpretation rather than as a doctrine explicitly stated in the text. Scripture clearly tells us that these were churches; it does not explicitly say, “These seven churches represent seven successive periods of Church history.” Nevertheless, the sequence presents a striking pattern worthy of consideration.

¹ Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations in this paper are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB).

I. The Seven Churches at a Glance

Church	What Jesus Praised	What Jesus Condemned	Central Spiritual Picture
<i>Ephesus</i>	Hard work, perseverance, discernment, rejection of false apostles, endurance	They had abandoned their first love	A doctrinally sound church whose love was cooling
<i>Smyrna</i>	Faithfulness in suffering and poverty; spiritual wealth	No specific condemnation	A suffering but faithful church
<i>Pergamum</i>	Holding firmly to Christ's name and not denying the faith	Tolerating false teaching and immorality	A church compromising with the surrounding culture
<i>Thyatira</i>	Love, faith, service, perseverance, and increasing works	Tolerating "Jezebel," sexual immorality, and idolatry	A loving and active church tolerating serious corruption
<i>Sardis</i>	A few had remained undefiled	Spiritual deadness and incomplete works	A church with a reputation for life but actually dying
<i>Philadelphia</i>	Keeping Christ's Word, not denying His name, and patient endurance	No specific condemnation	A small but faithful church
<i>Laodicea</i>	No commendation is given	Lukewarmness, self-sufficiency, spiritual blindness, poverty, and nakedness	A wealthy church that does not realize its spiritual poverty

The seven letters are found in Revelation 2:1–3:22. Their sequence follows the geographical arrangement of the churches in Asia Minor, beginning at Ephesus and moving generally north and then southeast toward Laodicea.

II. The Pattern in the Seven Letters

One of the striking features of these letters is that Jesus does not evaluate churches according to the standards by which churches often evaluate themselves. He does not begin with buildings, budgets, political influence, popularity, or numerical size. Instead, He repeatedly examines their *works, faithfulness, love, doctrine, endurance, purity, and obedience*.

This is especially important because Revelation begins with Christ standing among the seven golden lampstands. In Revelation 1:20, Jesus explains that the seven lampstands represent the seven churches. The picture is powerful. Jesus is not standing outside His churches. He is standing *among* them. He sees them, knows them, and has the authority to evaluate them.

The letters therefore provide something that is often missing from discussions about the Church: *Christ's evaluation of the Church.*

III. Ephesus — The Church That Lost Its First Love

Revelation 2:1–7

Ephesus receives one of the most remarkable commendations because this church was doctrinally discerning and hardworking. Jesus says, “*I know your deeds, your labor, and your patient endurance*” (Revelation 2:2). He commends them for refusing to tolerate wicked people and for testing those who claimed to be apostles but were not. They had discernment. They worked hard. They endured. They rejected false teaching.

Yet Jesus had something against them: “*But I have this against you: You have abandoned your first love*” (Revelation 2:4).

This is a sobering warning. A church can be doctrinally correct and spiritually cold. It can defend truth while losing its affection for Christ. It can expose false teachers while losing its own first love. The problem was not that Ephesus had stopped doing things. **The problem was that something had happened inside the doing.**

Jesus therefore tells them, “*Therefore remember the height from which you have fallen. Repent and perform the deeds you did at first*” (Revelation 2:5). **The remedy is remembrance, repentance, and restoration.**

Truth matters. Doctrine matters. Discernment matters. But truth without love can become cold orthodoxy. **Ephesus reminds us that a church can be right about many things and still be wrong about the most important thing: its love for Christ.**

IV. Smyrna — The Church That Suffered but Was Rich

Revelation 2:8–11

Smyrna demonstrates that suffering does not mean God has abandoned a church. Sometimes the most faithful church is the church experiencing the greatest pressure. The world measures wealth differently than Christ does. A church may be poor in the eyes of the world and rich in the eyes of God. Smyrna is a powerful reminder that persecution can purify rather than destroy the Church.

There is also an interesting historical observation connected with Smyrna. Of the seven ancient cities addressed in Revelation, Smyrna is the one that has continued as a major, living city to the present day. Ancient Smyrna is now modern İzmir, Turkey. The other ancient cities associated with the seven churches are represented primarily by archaeological ruins or ancient remains, while Smyrna continues as a thriving modern city.

The original first-century congregation addressed by Jesus cannot simply be identified with a single modern congregation. Nevertheless, Christianity has continued in İzmir, and a Christian community remains there today.

Whether this historical continuity carries prophetic significance cannot be stated with certainty. Yet it is certainly striking that the church Christ commended for its faithfulness in suffering, and to which He gave no condemnation, is associated with the only one of the seven ancient cities that has continued as a major living city until the present day.

Smyrna's message therefore remains especially powerful: *“Be faithful, even unto death, and I will give you the crown of life.”*

V. Pergamum — The Church That Compromised

Revelation 2:12–17

Pergamum lived in an extraordinarily difficult environment. Jesus describes it as the place “where Satan has his throne.” Yet He commends them for holding firmly to His name: *“Yet you have held fast to My name and have not denied your faith in Me”* (Revelation 2:13).

But there was a serious problem. Some within the church were holding to false teaching associated with Balaam and the Nicolaitans. The result was compromise involving idolatry and sexual immorality. Jesus therefore says, *“Nevertheless, I have a few things against you”* (Revelation 2:14).

The important issue is *toleration*. Pergamum had not completely abandoned Christ. It had simply allowed things into the church that Christ would not allow.

Compromise rarely begins with outright rejection of Christ. It often begins with tolerance. The church says, *“We still believe in Jesus,”* but gradually begins making room for teachings, practices, and values that contradict the Word of God. Pergamum warns that faithfulness requires more than merely confessing Christ's name. It requires refusing to accommodate what Christ condemns.

VI. Thyatira — The Church That Tolerated Corruption

Revelation 2:18–29

Thyatira is fascinating because Jesus gives it one of the strongest commendations of the seven churches: *“I know your deeds—your love and faith and service and perseverance—and I know that your latter deeds are greater than your first”* (Revelation 2:19).

Their later works were greater than their earlier works. They were growing in love, service, and perseverance. Yet something deeply serious existed within the church. Jesus says, *“But I have this against you: You tolerate the woman Jezebel”* (Revelation 2:20).

The name “Jezebel” may refer to a particular woman in the church or may be a symbolic designation for someone whose influence resembled the Old Testament Jezebel. Either way, the problem was that false teaching and immoral behavior were being *tolerated*.

This differs from Pergamum primarily in degree and expression. Pergamum had compromised. Thyatira had allowed corruption to establish itself.

A church can be active, loving, growing, and sacrificial—and still tolerate something Christ condemns. Love does not mean abandoning discernment. Grace does not mean calling sin acceptable. And tolerance is not always a virtue. Sometimes faithfulness requires confrontation.

VII. Sardis — The Church That Was Alive in Name Only

Revelation 3:1–6

Sardis receives perhaps the most devastating description of all: *“I know your deeds; you have a reputation for being alive, but you are dead”* (Revelation 3:1).

Imagine having a reputation for spiritual life while Jesus says you are spiritually dead. This is a warning against confusing reputation with reality. People may think a church is alive because it has a large congregation, impressive facilities, a successful ministry, a long history, a respected name, or a reputation for orthodoxy. But Jesus sees beneath appearances.

Yet even Sardis was not completely without hope. Jesus says, *“But you do have a few people in Sardis who have not soiled their garments”* (Revelation 3:4). There was still a faithful remnant. Jesus therefore commands, *“Wake up! Strengthen what remains and is about to die”* (Revelation 3:2).

A church can have a reputation for being alive and still be spiritually dying. But spiritual decline does not mean that everyone has fallen. Christ knows His faithful remnant.

VIII. Philadelphia — The Church of the Open Door

Revelation 3:7–13

Philadelphia is the second church, along with Smyrna, that receives no specific condemnation. Jesus says, *“I know your deeds. See, I have placed before you an open door that no one can shut”* (Revelation 3:8).

The open door speaks of an opportunity that Christ Himself has provided. What Christ opens, no one can shut. The church at Philadelphia may have possessed little worldly strength, but its limitations did not prevent Christ from using it.

Jesus says, *“You have only a little strength, yet you have kept My word and have not denied My name”* (Revelation 3:8).

That phrase is especially encouraging. Jesus did not condemn Philadelphia for having little strength. He did not tell them they needed to become powerful. Rather, despite their limited strength, they had remained faithful. They kept His Word and refused to deny His name.

Christ does not measure a church by worldly power, numbers, wealth, or influence. A small church can be profoundly faithful, and a church with little apparent strength can have extraordinary spiritual influence. The question is not simply, *“How much strength do we have?”* The more important question is, *“Are we faithfully using the strength Christ has given us?”*

Yet one of the most significant promises in the letter to Philadelphia is found in Revelation 3:10:

“Because you have kept My command to persevere, I will also keep you from the hour of trial that is coming upon the whole world, to test those who dwell on the earth.”

This promise is especially significant because the coming trial is not described as a local persecution or difficulty affecting Philadelphia. It is an *“hour of trial”* that will come *“upon the whole world”* to test *“those who dwell on the earth.”*

The wording is equally significant. Jesus does not merely promise to keep Philadelphia from the effects of the trial. He promises to keep them *“from the hour of trial”* itself. The promise therefore points beyond protection during a local persecution to deliverance from the coming worldwide period of testing.

Within the prophetic framework of Revelation, this worldwide hour of trial naturally points forward to the Tribulation described in the chapters that follow. The promise that Christ will keep His faithful people from that hour is therefore a significant anticipation of the Church's deliverance before the worldwide judgment unfolds.

Philadelphia had little strength, yet it kept Christ's Word. It faced opposition, yet it did not deny His name. It persevered, and Christ promised both an open door of opportunity and deliverance from the coming hour of worldwide testing.

The message remains deeply encouraging. Christ does not require worldly strength before He can use His people. He calls for faithfulness. And those who faithfully keep His Word and refuse to deny His name can rest in the knowledge that the One who opens doors no one can shut also knows how to keep His people.

IX. Laodicea — The Lukewarm Church

Revelation 3:14–22

Laodicea is the only church to which Jesus gives no commendation. Instead, He says, *“I know your deeds; you are neither cold nor hot. I wish you were one or the other!”* (Revelation 3:15).

Their problem was lukewarmness, but the deeper problem was self-sufficiency. Laodicea said, “*I am rich; I have grown wealthy and need nothing.*” Jesus answered, “*But you do not realize that you are wretched, pitiful, poor, blind, and naked*” (Revelation 3:17).

The contrast could hardly be greater. They thought they were rich; Jesus said they were poor. They thought they could see; Jesus said they were blind. They thought they needed nothing; Jesus said they needed everything.

Here the door is shut, but the church members need only open it. Jesus says, “*Behold, I stand at the door and knock*” (Revelation 3:20). This verse is frequently used evangelistically, and rightly so in its broader application. Yet its immediate context is striking: *Jesus is speaking to a church.*

It is possible for a church to become so self-sufficient that Christ is effectively standing outside the fellowship that bears His name.

Prosperity can create a spiritual danger that persecution does not. Persecution says, “*You need God.*” Comfort says, “*You have enough.*” Suffering can drive us toward Christ, while prosperity can tempt us to believe we no longer need Him.

X. What the Seven Churches Reveal About the Church

When the seven churches are viewed together, an extraordinary picture emerges:

- *Ephesus* — truth without sufficient love.
- *Smyrna* — suffering with faithfulness.
- *Pergamum* — faith mixed with compromise.
- *Thyatira* — love and service mixed with tolerated corruption.
- *Sardis* — reputation without spiritual life.
- *Philadelphia* — little strength but great faithfulness.
- *Laodicea* — material prosperity accompanied by spiritual poverty.

This is more than an ancient history lesson. It is a mirror. Almost every church can find itself somewhere in these seven letters, and perhaps most churches can find themselves in more than one.

A congregation might possess the doctrinal discernment of Ephesus while struggling with its loss of first love. It might possess the courage of Smyrna while facing the temptation of Pergamum. It might possess the service of Thyatira while tolerating something it should confront. It might have the reputation of Sardis, desire the faithfulness of Philadelphia, or unknowingly drift toward the self-sufficiency of Laodicea.

That is why Jesus repeatedly says, “*He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.*” The message is not merely for *them*. It is for *us*.

XI. Do the Seven Churches Represent Seven Church Ages?

There is a longstanding interpretation that sees the seven churches as representing not only seven actual first-century congregations, but also a possible prophetic progression through the history of the Church.

This interpretation is sometimes called the *prophetic*, *historical*, or *church-age* interpretation. According to this view, the sequence of the seven churches may correspond broadly with major spiritual developments that have appeared throughout the history of Christianity. Some Protestant interpreters have proposed variations of this understanding for centuries.

The important point, however, is that Revelation does not assign specific dates to these churches or explicitly state that each one represents a precise chronological period of Church history. Therefore, it is unnecessary—and perhaps unwise—to force the letters into rigid historical boundaries.

It is enough to recognize the possibility of a broad progression:

Church	Possible Historical Picture	Characteristic
<i>Ephesus</i>	The early apostolic Church	Sound doctrine, labor, and discernment, yet a danger of losing its first love
<i>Smyrna</i>	The persecuted Church	Faithfulness in suffering, poverty, and martyrdom
<i>Pergamum</i>	The Church gaining acceptance and influence in the world	Holding Christ's name while increasingly tempted by compromise
<i>Thyatira</i>	The long period of institutional Christianity and religious authority	Genuine love and service mixed with tolerated corruption and false teaching
<i>Sardis</i>	The era of Reformation and spiritual recovery	Important truth recovered, yet the danger of possessing a reputation for life without complete spiritual renewal
<i>Philadelphia</i>	A period of missionary expansion and renewed evangelical faithfulness	Open doors, faithfulness to Christ's Word, and perseverance despite limited strength
<i>Laodicea</i>	The Church near the end of the age	Prosperity, self-sufficiency, lukewarmness, and a failure to recognize spiritual poverty

The parallels between this progression and the broad history of Christianity are certainly interesting. The early Church was marked by apostolic zeal and doctrinal struggle, followed by centuries of severe persecution. Later, Christianity moved from persecution to acceptance and eventually became closely connected with political and institutional power. The following

centuries witnessed both genuine Christian devotion and serious corruption. The Reformation recovered vital biblical truths, missionary movements carried the Gospel around the world, and the modern Church faces unprecedented prosperity and opportunity while simultaneously confronting the danger of spiritual complacency and self-sufficiency.

For this reason, it is reasonable to see a possible prophetic pattern in the sequence of the seven churches. Yet the pattern should not be forced. We do not need to say that one church suddenly ended and another began on a particular date, nor should we assume that the characteristics of one church completely disappeared before the characteristics of the next appeared. Church history is far more complex than that.

Perhaps it is better to understand the seven churches as a *progressive pattern* rather than seven rigidly defined historical ages. Their characteristics may have become particularly prominent at different points in history while continuing to exist throughout the entire Church age.

Thus, there have always been churches like Ephesus—churches that defend truth but risk losing their first love. There have always been Smyrna-like believers suffering faithfully for Christ, Pergamum-like churches tempted to compromise with the world, and Thyatira-like churches in which genuine devotion exists alongside tolerated corruption. There have always been Sardis-like churches with a reputation for spiritual life but little genuine vitality, and Philadelphia-like churches possessing little worldly strength yet faithfully keeping Christ's Word and refusing to deny His name. There have also been Laodicean tendencies wherever prosperity, comfort, and self-sufficiency have caused believers to lose their sense of dependence upon Christ.

The seven churches may therefore be understood on more than one level. They were seven literal churches existing in the first century. They represent spiritual conditions found in churches throughout every generation. And they may also reveal a broad prophetic progression through the history of the Church.

The last possibility should be held as an interpretation rather than as an explicitly stated doctrine. The characteristics of the seven churches overlap, and the practical message remains unchanged: Christ is still evaluating His churches, and every generation must ask which of these conditions most resembles them.

XII. Ephesus and the Early Apostolic Church

Ephesus naturally corresponds with the early apostolic Church in this possible historical progression.

The early Church was marked by apostolic preaching, evangelistic activity, doctrinal development, persecution, endurance, and devotion to Christ. Yet even during the apostolic period, warnings of spiritual decline and false teaching appeared.

By the time Revelation was written, Ephesus had strong doctrinal discernment, but Jesus said it had abandoned its first love.

The historical parallel is therefore significant: a Church can begin with extraordinary zeal and devotion while gradually becoming more focused on defending truth than loving the One who is Truth.

XIII. Smyrna and the Persecuted Church

Smyrna naturally calls to mind the persecuted Church, particularly the early centuries when Christians suffered under the Roman Empire.

Jesus did not tell Smyrna to compromise to escape suffering. He told them:

“Be faithful, even unto death, and I will give you the crown of life.”

— Revelation 2:10

The historical picture fits the character of Smyrna: suffering, poverty, endurance, and faithfulness.

Yet Smyrna is not limited to one historical period. Whenever believers suffer because they refuse to deny Christ, the Smyrna pattern is present.

XIV. Pergamum and the Church's Growing Accommodation to the World

Pergamum provides a striking picture of the transition from persecution to acceptance.

As Christianity gained social influence and eventually political connection, the Church faced a different kind of test. The danger was no longer simply persecution but the temptation to compromise in order to preserve acceptance, influence, and power.

That makes Pergamum particularly relevant to this historical progression.

The lesson remains timeless:

The greatest danger to the Church is not always persecution. Sometimes it is acceptance.

Every generation must ask whether the Church is changing the culture or allowing the culture to change the Church.

XV. Thyatira and Institutional Christianity

Thyatira is often associated with the long period in which Christianity became deeply connected with institutional religious authority.

The comparison rests on the combination of genuine faith, love, service, and perseverance with serious corruption and tolerated false teaching.

The historical parallel should not be understood as a condemnation of every believer during that period. Jesus Himself recognized faithful believers within Thyatira.

The lesson is that even during periods of institutional corruption, Christ preserves those who remain faithful to Him.

XVI. Sardis and the Recovery of Biblical Truth

Sardis is frequently associated with the Protestant Reformation because the Reformation brought a remarkable recovery of central biblical truths, particularly the authority of Scripture and justification by faith.

Yet Sardis also provides an important qualification:

“You have a reputation for being alive, but you are dead.”

— Revelation 3:1

The recovery of biblical truth does not automatically produce complete spiritual renewal. Correct doctrine is essential, but truth must also be believed, lived, loved, and allowed to transform the Church.

XVII. Philadelphia and the Expansion of the Gospel

Philadelphia is frequently associated with renewed evangelical faithfulness and the great missionary expansion that carried the Gospel into many parts of the world.

Jesus said:

“See, I have placed before you an open door that no one can shut.”

— Revelation 3:8

The open door provides a fitting picture of missionary opportunity, while Philadelphia's limited strength reminds us that the expansion of the Gospel does not depend upon worldly power.

Revelation 3:10 is especially significant within the possible prophetic progression. Christ promises to keep His faithful people from *“the hour of trial that is coming upon the whole world.”* As discussed earlier, this promise anticipates the Rapture of the Church before the Tribulation.

The sequence is also striking: Philadelphia represents faithfulness and perseverance, while Laodicea follows with prosperity, self-sufficiency, and lukewarmness.

The historical parallels are suggestive rather than absolute, but the practical message remains clear: Christ honors those who keep His Word, refuse to deny His name, and persevere until He comes.

XVIII. Laodicea and the Church Near the End of the Age

Laodicea is perhaps the most provocative comparison in the proposed historical progression.

The church is characterized by lukewarmness, material prosperity, self-sufficiency, spiritual blindness, and an inability to recognize its true condition.

That description can apply to churches in every generation. Yet many interpreters believe Laodicea has particular relevance to the Church as it approaches the end of the age.

The modern Church, especially in prosperous societies, possesses unprecedented access to Bibles, theological resources, Christian books, churches, seminaries, technology, broadcasting, the internet, and financial resources. Yet abundance does not necessarily produce spiritual depth.

It is possible to have abundant religious resources while losing genuine dependence upon Christ. It is possible to study extensively *about Christ* while gradually losing the desire to *know Christ*.

That is the danger of Laodicea.

If the seven churches reveal a broad progression through Church history, it is significant that the final picture is not a Church destroyed by persecution, but a Church endangered by comfort, prosperity, and self-sufficiency.

Yet even Laodicea is not beyond hope. Christ calls His people to repent and return to fellowship with Him. Even in an age of increasing apostasy and compromise, faithful believers can still hear His voice and overcome.

XIX. Notice Where Jesus Places the Emphasis

There is another remarkable feature of these letters. Jesus does not primarily ask, “*What age are you living in?*” He asks, “*Are you faithful to Me?*”

He does not tell Ephesus to determine its place on a prophetic timeline. He tells Ephesus to repent. He does not tell Smyrna to calculate when persecution will end. He tells Smyrna to remain faithful. He does not tell Pergamum to identify its historical period. He tells Pergamum to repent of compromise. He does not tell Thyatira to debate Church history. He tells Thyatira to confront corruption. He does not tell Sardis to analyze its reputation. He tells Sardis to wake up. He does not tell Philadelphia to become powerful. He tells Philadelphia to hold fast. And He

does not tell Laodicea to accumulate greater wealth. He tells Laodicea to recognize its spiritual poverty and come back to Him.

That is the heart of the seven letters.

XX. The Seven Churches and the Return of Christ

There is also an important connection between these letters and the larger message of Revelation. The letters prepare the reader for everything that follows. Jesus is about to reveal the judgment of the world, the rise of the Beast, the final conflict, His return, His reign, the judgment, and the eternal state.

But before Revelation shows us what is happening *to the world*, Christ shows us what is happening *inside His Church*.

That order is significant. Before we study the Beast, we should listen to Christ. Before we examine Babylon, we should examine ourselves. Before we discuss the Antichrist, we should ask whether we are remaining faithful to Christ. Before we look at the final apostasy, we should ask whether our own love is growing cold.

The seven churches therefore function almost like a spiritual examination before the prophetic drama unfolds.

XXI. Every Letter Calls for Overcoming

One of the most encouraging themes throughout these letters is the repeated promise to “*the one who overcomes*.” Christ does not merely expose problems. He calls His people to overcome them.

The Ephesians can recover their first love. The persecuted can remain faithful. Those tempted by compromise can repent. Those tolerating corruption can separate themselves from it. Those who are spiritually asleep can wake up. Those with little strength can hold fast. Those who are lukewarm can open the door.

The letters are therefore not merely condemnations. They are *calls to repentance and perseverance*. Christ's purpose is not merely to tell His Church what is wrong. It is to call His Church back to Himself.

XXII. What Jesus Requires of His Church

When the seven letters are considered together, the pattern becomes unmistakable. Jesus honors faithfulness, love, service, perseverance, doctrinal discernment, purity, holding firmly to His name, keeping His Word, and refusing compromise.

He condemns loss of love, false teaching, compromise, immorality, tolerated corruption, spiritual deadness, self-sufficiency, lukewarmness, and failure to repent.

Notice that Jesus never condemns Smyrna because it is poor. He never condemns Philadelphia because it is weak. The problem is not weakness. The problem is *unfaithfulness*.

A church does not have to be large to please Christ. It does not have to be wealthy, politically influential, or culturally admired. It has to be faithful.

Conclusion: Hear What the Spirit Says

The seven churches were real churches. They existed in real cities. They faced real problems. Jesus addressed each congregation according to its particular condition. But their messages did not end in the first century.

The repeated command is, *“He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.”*

Notice the plural. Not merely, *“What the Spirit says to Ephesus,”* or, *“What the Spirit says to Smyrna,”* but what the Spirit says *“to the churches.”*

The seven letters therefore belong to the whole Church.

Their characteristics have existed throughout the Church age and continue to exist today. Whether or not the seven churches also provide a broad prophetic progression through Church history, their practical message is unmistakable.

Christ has always known the true condition of His Church.

He knows when a church is laboring. He knows when it is suffering. He knows when it is compromising. He knows when it is tolerating sin. He knows when it is spiritually dead. He knows when it is weak but faithful. And He knows when it has become rich, comfortable, and completely unaware of its spiritual poverty.

The seven churches therefore give us a remarkable picture of the Church between Christ's first coming and His second coming.

Throughout the entire Church age, the same question remains:

Will the Church remain faithful to Christ?

That brings us back to the words of Jesus to Philadelphia:

“I am coming soon. Hold fast to what you have, so that no one will take your crown.”

— Revelation 3:11

That may be the most appropriate summary of all seven letters:

Hold fast.

Whatever age we may believe we are living in, and whatever condition we may see around us, the ultimate issue is not the age of the Church.

The ultimate issue is whether we are listening to Christ and remaining faithful to Him.

And the final word of the seven letters is not despair. It is promise:

“To the one who overcomes, I will grant the right to sit with Me on My throne.”

— Revelation 3:21

The One who walks among the lampstands is still speaking.

The question is whether we have ears to hear.